

COLONIAL WRAP
Some pre-independence paper labels with trademarks advertising British textiles

ADVERTISING

What's in a Label?

COLONIAL-ERA ADVERTISEMENTS COME ALIVE IN TICKET TIKA CHAAP, AN EXHIBITION OF TEXTILE LABELS AT MAP BENGALURU





EACH PAPER LABEL HAS A TRADEMARK, AND REFLECTS LEGENDS, BELIEFS AND TRADITIONS. THE CORE IS ABOUT ADVERTISEMENT AND SHOWS THE APPEAL OF THE IMAGES

A woman in a gown riding a chariot pulled by four tigers. A king and queen perched on a globe surrounded by horsemen. Two elephants engaged in a tug of war. If you are wondering what they have in common—well, these are all chromolithograph prints of textile labels from the late 19th to the early 20th century. On display as part of the exhibition *Ticket Tika Chaap* at MAP Bengaluru, these paper labels are incredibly rich, detailed, colourful, and yet relatively forgotten. The labels were stuck on yardages of cloth that came to India from Britain.

MAP houses a collection of over 7,000 textile labels, and 300 have been selected for the show after two years of curatorial research by Nathaniel Gaskell and Shrey Maurya. "Manchester was the centre of this industrial mill revolution, and these labels came post the passing of the trademark act and the invention of chromolithography that allowed mass printing," explains Maurya.

Each of these paper labels is a trademark and has a striking image at the centre, a border space that has the name of the selling agent and their locations. The wide range of imagery on these labels were chosen to appeal to the customer. Impeccably designed, the core is about advertisement. "You appeal to people's sense of devotion, their desire for a beautiful woman or man, to have a laugh, or feel part of modernity," says Maurya.

The images reflect legends, beliefs and traditions and show inspiration, imitation and appropriation. This exhibition tells a story of a world poised at the precipice of something new and the story of what inspired and appealed to people, making the labels invaluable markers of that time. ■

—Bindu Gopal Rao

On until November. 2, at MAP Bengaluru, Citi Gallery, Third Floor, Kasturba Road